

HORS D'OEUVRES | DILIP BOBB

The Angel Wears Prada



The Americans have come up with a phrase that best describes the human condition in these tough economic times: 'The New Normal'. It's pretty clever when you think about it because no one, to use another popular downturn phrase, is recession-proof. The new reality is that everybody pretends things are normal while downsizing their lives and lifestyles. In extreme situations, catchphrases sprout like, well..., green shoots, or even yellow weeds, the two corporate buzzwords that signify an economic recovery or a lack of it. We already have a new recession vocabulary with words such as staycation, toxic debts, boomeranger (adult children returning to their parents' homes), and weisure, sacrificing leisure time for working longer hours. Then there's the one I love with shades of Sarah Palin, 'the Lipstick Effect', or finding new and cheaper ways to improve and modify your home or appearance.

And then there's the phrase that is literally cutting edge: recessionista. It's a derivative of 'recession chic' and refers to style mavens who are desperately trying to figure out how to stay stylish during times of personal cutbacks. While there are also phrases like inconspicuous consumption and stealth shopper, recessionista has a resonance. Being stylish but price conscious is the New Normal. In Oxford Street, most stores, including mid-level Marks & Spencer, are half empty. Opposite M&S is Primark, the discount store which stocks stylish but cheap garments.



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It is packed. Fashionista's younger, hipper sister—recessionista—is busy finding designer threads at discount prices.

Vogue magazine has declared the free-spending fashionista of the type lionised in *Sex and the City* as passé. Instead, there are new icons for the new austerity, people who can find ways to look trendy even when they are spending less: The Angel wears Prada, as most retailers will call them. In India, Levis is offering payment by EMI. Bourjois, a makeup line from France, is promoting the brand's mascara and lip glosses as "the Recessionista Collection".

The idea behind the new retail strategy is to send a subliminal message that because consumers are spending less and still getting value, it is more than okay to shop. Phrases like recessionista help people approach grim realities through humour, says Kathleen Hall Jamieson, director of the Annenberg Public Policy Center at the University of Pennsylvania. "When people start becoming playful with language, that's a coping mechanism," she said. Indeed, "recessionista" does carry an upbeat tone. However, it does come with a rider. If the economy worsens, be prepared for yet another phrase, depressionista.

SIGNPOSTS

GROUNDING: By the Indian Navy, its entire fleet of 11 **Sea Harriers** after one of them crashed. India's lone aircraft carrier, the *INS Viraat*, is now bereft of its aerial firepower.

CONFERRED: On Tathagat Avatar Tulsi by the Indian Institute of Science, a doctorate for his pioneering research on next-



generation software for quantum computers. At 21, he is one of the youngest scientists with a doctorate.

SENTENCED: Harpreet Singh and Satyender Singh of the elite Presidential Bodyguard, for life for raping a student in the Buddha Jayanti Park near Rashtrapati Bhavan in 2003. Two others got 10 years each.

ARRESTED: Ramakant Yadav, BJP MP from Azamgarh, in connection with a murder and attempt to murder case lodged against him.

APPOINTED: Nengcha Lhouvum Mukhopadhyay as the next ambassador to Serbia. She is the Indian envoy in Lebanon and will succeed Ajay Swarup.